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Women Who Work: The limits of the neoliberal feminist paradigm

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This article examines Ivanka Trump's *Women Who Work*, arguing that it represents the newest permutation of the neoliberal feminist subject. After providing an overview of the recent emergence of neoliberal feminism, I explain why the book should be considered part of the wider cultural landscape in which this variant of feminism has increasingly become commonsensical. I then turn to demonstrate how *Women Who Work* construes the ideal female subject not only as generic human capital but also incites her to invest in herself constantly, where activities ranging from professional workshops through hobbies to friendships are understood as practices that appreciate the value of the self. The conversion of women into generic rather than gendered human capital remains, however, incomplete, since the ideal of a happy work–family balance continues to serve as a push back to the wholesale erasure of traditional notions of sexual difference. Finally, I highlight that neoliberal feminism is erasing other long-standing divisions and political differences. Not only does the private–public divide collapse, but so, too, does the distinction between one's private self and one's public enterprise as the self itself becomes an enterprise. This dual process of collapse and reconfiguration shapes the newest neoliberal feminist subject, the main protagonist of Trump's *Women Who Work*.

KEYWORDS

neoliberal feminism, work-family balance, Ivanka Trump, Women Who Work, human capital, neoliberal rationality

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1 | INTRODUCTION

When Ivanka Trump's how-to-succeed guide *Women Who Work: Rewriting the Rules for Success* was released in May 2017, it generated a flurry of negative reviews in the mainstream media (i.e., Brooks, 2017). Many commentators excoriated the book, claiming that this newest 'having it all' manifesto is composed of jargon, which could just as easily have been found by Googling 'inspirational quotes' (Tolentino, 2017). Summing up the general reaction, Megan Garber (2017) explains that Trump's book has been dismissed in large part because it relies on upbeat platitudes to convey a message of female empowerment while offering a vision of feminism that is not very feminist at all. Yet, notwithstanding this widespread criticism, *Women Who Work* quickly became a *New York Times* bestseller and, to date, continues to sell well.

While it is true that *Women Who Work* is littered with clichés and unabashedly endorses the Ivanka lifestyle brand, I suggest that Trump's manifesto warrants serious analysis. Her main message — and the one that serves as her repetitive mantra — is that women should work on all facets of their life, namely their 'career, relationship, family, friendships, hobbies, and passions' (Trump, 2017, p. 133). The address is directed, not surprisingly, toward so-called aspirational women (see Allen, 2014; McRobbie, 2009), who are incessantly incited to achieve their 'best self', both professionally and personally. Success is defined as facing obstacles with resilience, initiative and creativity, while one's ability to thrive is described as 'limited only by one's own hunger, drive, passion, and execution' (Trump, 2017, p. 91). According to Trump, then, empowerment and achievement involve individual women consciously choosing to create the life they desire and proactively crafting such a life through continuous labour and perseverance.

It is in this way that *Women Who Work* captures and reproduces a key contemporary and neoliberal expectation that individuals — and particularly women — should never cease working on themselves in order to enhance their value. The book deserves serious attention precisely for the way that it lays bare the intensive labour — affective and physical — that women are expected to invest in themselves in order to approximate the contemporary norm of female — and as I will argue *feminist* — accomplishment (see also Elias, Gill, & Scharff, 2017; Gill & Orgad, 2015, 2017; McRobbie, 2015; Scharff, 2017). Furthermore, a close examination of *Women Who Work* reveals that the ideal female subject is not only conceived of (and incited to conceive herself) as human capital but the self is produced as well as produces itself as 'an individual firm' or business enterprise, where all activities and practices are understood as investments that aim to appreciate the value of the self-as-firm. Trump's text, in other words, encourages women to consider themselves as a form of 'stock', where their normative role is to augment their market value. This entails incessant labour, particularly the modification of behaviour, aspirations and affective orientation — much like a corporation that alters its practices in an attempt to increase its stocks' value by becoming more 'efficient' (see Feher, 2009). The woman-as-stock framework, I argue, conjures the newest permutation of the neoliberal feminist subject, since she is completely shorn of any and all liberal trappings.

In order to make the argument that Trump's manifesto can and should be read as registering and helping to constitute the newest permutation of the neoliberal feminist subject, I first provide an overview of my theoretical arguments with respect to the rise of neoliberal feminism and the engendering of the neoliberal feminist subject (Rottenberg, 2014b, 2018). I simultaneously underscore that the book should not be considered an outlier but, rather, as part and parcel of the wider cultural landscape in which neoliberal feminism has increasingly become part of mainstream common sense. I then turn to analyse *Women Who Work* in some detail, showing how neoliberal feminism is erasing long-standing divisions and political differences. This erasure pivots on neoliberal rationality's colonization of more domains of our lives, refiguring these domains in market metrics while undoing conceptual and political boundaries constitutive of liberalism and liberal thought. Not only does the private–public divide collapse, but so, too, does the distinction between one's 'private' self and one's 'public' enterprise as the self itself becomes an enterprise. This dual process of collapse and reconfiguration shapes the ideal neoliberal feminist subject, the main protagonist of Trump's *Women Who Work*.

1.1 | The rise of neoliberal feminism

As I have argued elsewhere (Rottenberg, 2014a, 2014b, 2017, 2018), in the past half-decade we have witnessed the publication of a flurry of feminist manifestos that have garnered intense media attention and re-energized feminist

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debates in the United States, most trenchantly around the question of why well-educated middle-class women are still struggling to cultivate careers and raise children at the same time. Two of these, former Princeton University professor Anne-Marie Slaughter's (2012) 'Why Women Still Can't Have it All' and Facebook's chief operating officer Sheryl Sandberg's (2013) bestselling *Lean In: Women, Work, and the Will to Lead* might well be said to have initiated a trend of high-powered women publicly identifying as feminists. Concurrently, there has been a veritable explosion of feminist discourse in popular and mainstream venues in both the United States and UK. This is what Sarah Banet-Weiser (2018; Banet-Weiser & Portwood-Stacer, 2017) has aptly termed popular feminism. Yet, feminist themes have not merely been popularized and 'mainstreamed', but, as scholars such as Lynne Segal (2017a, 2017b), Nancy Fraser (2013) and Angela McRobbie (2013, 2015) have argued in different contexts, they have also become increasingly compatible with neoliberal political and economic agendas (see also Eisenstein, 2009; Farris, 2017; Fisher, 2017; Prügl, 2015; Wilson, 2015).

Building on the growing scholarship that attempts to account for the mutual entanglement of feminism and neoliberalism, I have argued that we have been witnessing the emergence of a new variant of feminism, one that revolves centrally around the notion of a happy work–family balance. Balance has not only been incorporated into the social imagination as a cultural good but has helped to engender a new model of emancipated womanhood: a professional woman able to balance a successful career with a satisfying family life. A 'happy work–family balance', in other words, is currently being (re)presented not merely as a normative ideal for women but as a progressive *feminist* ideal, particularly in the Anglo-American world (Orgad, 2017, 2018; Rottenberg, 2014a; see also Adamson, 2017; Armstrong, 2017). This new feminist ideal must be understood as helping to shape women's desires, aspirations and behaviour, as well as producing a feminist subject informed through and through by a market metrics. I call this new variant of feminism neoliberal feminism and show how it has been unsettlingly unmoored from key liberal political goals such as equality, justice and emancipation. Disavowing the socioeconomic and cultural structures shaping our lives, this feminism spawns a feminist subject who accepts full responsibility for her own wellbeing and self-care, which are predicated on crafting a felicitous work–family balance, which is itself based on a cost–benefit — namely, a market — calculus.

It is important to underscore that I do not understand neoliberalism merely as an economic system or a set of policies that facilitate intensified privatization and deregulation, but rather, following political theorists Michel Feher (2009) and Wendy Brown (2015, 2016), as a dominant political rationality that moves to and from the management of the state to the inner workings of the subject. In his germinal article 'Self-appreciation; Or, the Aspirations of Human Capital', Feher (2009) describes the historic shift in governance that has occurred under neoliberalism's hegemony, arguing that neoliberalism is creating new forms of subjectivation, which produce human beings as human capital. Human beings consequently become investors in themselves as capital, wishing to enhance their own value over time. Feher further claims that neoliberalism's 'subjective apparatus' — the apparatus through which subjects are constituted and gain intelligibility — is radically different from the one operating under liberalism. If under liberalism human beings are conceived of as free labourers with labour power to sell, under neoliberalism human beings are engendered as subjects who cultivate a *speculative* relationship to the human capital that they have become. The focus accordingly shifts from selling labour or even human capital in the marketplace to increasing one's value everywhere — and all the time — by altering and diversifying assets or modifying behaviours and social interactions. Every alteration or lack thereof is considered either to appreciate or depreciate the value of the self-as-human-capital.

Brown (2016) has more recently claimed that neoliberalism is economizing political and social life in distinctive ways, producing subjects for which consumption, education, training and mate-selection are all configured as practices of self-investment, where the self is perceived not only an as entrepreneur, as scholars such as Nikolas Rose (1992) have already argued, but also as an individual firm or business enterprise. Moreover, through processes of devolution and responsibilization, neoliberal governance constructs and manages subjects who are configured as agents wholly responsible and blameable for their own individual lives.[1] The conversion of subjects — and, I argue, particularly female subjects — into self-investing capital consequently undoes traditional forms of social ties and relations. Furthermore, given that neoliberalism is remoulding all spheres of life into the model of the market — where competition and capital appreciation override all else — the world is, according to Cruz and Brown (2016),

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increasingly becoming a place in which there are only winners and losers, capital-enhancing subjects and those deemed 'disposable' because they are 'unbankable'.

And, yet, even as neoliberal rationality colonizes more and more domains of our lives, recasting them in market terms, I suggest that neoliberalism may actually 'need' feminism to resolve — at least temporarily — one of its internal tensions in relation to gender. As an economic order, neoliberalism relies on reproduction and care work in order to reproduce and maintain human capital. However, as a political rationality — and in stark contrast to liberalism — neoliberalism has no lexicon that can recognize let alone value reproduction and care work. Everything is reduced to a market metrics — even our political imagination. The disappearance of a distinctive political lexicon is not only due to human subjects being increasingly converted into generic human capital, where gender is disavowed, but also because the division of the public–private spheres — informing liberal thought and the traditional sexual division of labour — is being eroded through the conversion of everything into capital and the infiltration of a market rationality into all spheres of life, including the most private ones. Different registers — political, economic, social and affective — collapse under neoliberalism, and all forms of valuation transpire through a cost–benefit metrics.

Neoliberal feminism has, in other words, been operating as a kind of pushback to the total conversion of educated and upwardly mobile women into generic human capital. By paradoxically and counter-intuitively maintaining reproduction as part of middle-class or so-called aspirational women's normative trajectory and positing *balance* as its normative frame and ultimate ideal, neoliberal *feminism* helps to both maintain a discourse of reproduction and care work while ensuring that all responsibility for these forms of labour — but not necessarily all of the labour itself — falls squarely on the shoulders of aspirational women. In this way it solves its own constitutive tension — the quandary of reproduction and care work — at least temporarily. Indeed, neoliberal *feminism* produces and maintains a distinctive and affective lexiconic register of reproductive and care work within neoliberalism, even as neoliberal rationality collapses the private–public divide.

2 | WOMEN WHO WORK

An analysis of *Women Who Work* reveals that the book not only assumes the neoliberal feminist subject I have outlined above but also conjures a subject who further propels or accelerates the conversion of so-called aspirational women into generic rather than gendered human capital. As I will show, this is best exemplified in the reworking of motherhood in increasingly managerial terms. However, this conversion process still remains incomplete, since the ideal of a happy work–family balance continues to serve as a pushback to the complete erasure of traditional notions of sexual difference. Indeed, if reproduction and balance were not retained as part of the discussion, then the transformation of aspirational women into generic human capital would be more or less 'complete' and neoliberal feminist discourse would disappear. It is precisely through maintaining balance as part of its ideal on the one hand, while furthering the conversion of women into specks of human capital through construing motherhood in managerial terms on the other, that neoliberal feminism appears to move closer towards its logical limit.

Like many of the bestselling neoliberal feminist manifestos that have been published in the last few years, such as Sheryl Sandberg's (2013) *Lean In* and Megyn Kelly's (2016) *Settle for More*, Trump clearly states her conviction that working towards greater gender equality is of paramount importance, explicitly acknowledging that gender parity has yet to be reached in the United States. In her introductory chapter, for instance, Trump (2017, pp. 4, 211) declares that despite the progress and the many advances women in America have made since her mother's generation, 'we've still got a long way to go'. Moreover, she advocates for certain structural changes, such as paid maternity leave and 'affordable, high-quality childcare'. These avowals of continued gender inequality, which can be understood as one of the signs marking the shift from a postfeminist moment to a feminist one, are, however, overlaid by a much more profound and general disavowal.[2] Trump spends approximately one page of her 212-page book expounding on structural obstacles. The overwhelming majority of the advice and instruction given by Trump to less famous and wealthy women revolves around the labour individual women are required to invest in themselves in order to achieve success.

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Indeed, Trump (2017, pp. 47, 176) insists that women must 'plot a plan for success' and if they are passionate, work hard and are committed to excellence, they will inevitably succeed. The underlying assumption, then, is that individual women are ultimately responsible for both their successes and their failures.

Women Who Work can therefore be read as exposing the processes through which aspirational women are interpellated as (potentially) capital-enhancing subjects. Through her constant exhortation that women invest in and labour on all domains of their lives, Trump reveals, performs and helps to (re)produce the conversion of women from ostensible autonomous rights bearing liberal subjects who need to fight discrimination in order to gain access to the marketplace to sell their labour into subjects who must work tirelessly on themselves in order to produce and cultivate their selves *as* human capital. This human capital, she intimates, must be cultivated continuously: 'Work hard … and challenge yourself in every aspect of your life' (Trump, 2017, p. 74). Every facet of the self thus becomes a site of speculation, intense scrutiny and affective investment — a process whose objective is to increase and diversify the self's assets, to facilitate its appreciation, but just as importantly, to prevent its depreciation.

This 'totalizing' approach to the self as human capital serves to facilitate the transmutation of the self into a business enterprise, while simultaneously helping to further unravel the private–public divide. The neoliberal subject herself — recast as an individual firm — is compelled and encouraged to perceive all aspects of her life and self — including reproduction and care work — as requiring continuous capital investment, rendering the separation of public–private increasingly unintelligible. In other words, as neoliberal rationality transforms more and more elements of society into enterprises informed by a business model with financialization at its heart, not only do all remaining private–public distinctions collapse but the self (itself) becomes increasingly indistinguishable from any other kind of business enterprise, which ultimately undermines the very logic upholding the separation between the spheres.

Trump's manifesto reveals as well as enacts the twofold and concurrent collapsing of these traditionally distinct realms: the public versus the private as well as one's enterprise versus one's self. Following her prolonged introduction, Trump (2017, pp. 28, 47) urges women to draft a personal mission statement, which, she claims, will pay certain 'dividends' in the future by helping them to identify their passions and 'true north'. This exercise will help them maximize their influence later on. After identifying what their passions are — preferably in their twenties — women are subsequently encouraged to enter the business or professional world and to cultivate a wide array of capabilities, such as networking and negotiating deals 'thoughtfully and effectively'. These capabilities are depicted as part of the self's overall 'portfolio of conducts' (Feher, 2009, p. 30), which are considered key for increasing the probabilities of creating a successful enterprise and 'making one's mark' (Trump, 2017, p. 14).

Yet this is precisely the moment when the boundary between self and business becomes blurred, since the advice to foster these abilities — networking, negotiating skills — is meant to enhance not only the business one works for (or runs) but also — and perhaps most crucially — the self itself. This helps explain why *Women Who Work* repeatedly insists that it is important for women who have begun to make their mark professionally to create to-do charts to 'prioritize [their] time so that [they] are always adding value' (Trump, 2017, p. 121). Planning well, which includes making endless lists about what women want to accomplish — from mission statements to everyday colour-coded to-do lists — is central to ensuring that hard work will enhance value and yield the proper results. The self becomes, in the words of feminist theorist Angela McRobbie (2015, p. 10), a kind of 'neoliberal spreadsheet' indistinguishable from a business, where one calculates one's assets, one's losses and what is more or less valuable in order to decide where more capital investment — in the form of developing entrepreneurial skills, resources or capacities — is necessary. In *Women Who Work*, the self has indeed been unashamedly transformed into an enterprise and, as such, there is no longer any need to presuppose the separation of the private and public spheres.

The reconfiguration and collapse of the private–public divide is perhaps most evident as Trump (2017, p. 128) includes domains traditionally and historically excluded from notions of 'boosting one's productivity' and 'maximizing one's efficiency' in neoliberalism's calculative schema. Hobbies, friendships and other intimate relationships that under liberalism were separate — at least conceptually — from a calculative matrix are now carefully remade into forms of investment and value management. As Joan Scott (2017, p. 13) has recently highlighted, the public and private dichotomy historically separated, conceptually, the 'market and politics' from 'home and family' as well as 'affective

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relationality'. While *Women Who Work* merely intimates that decisions about who one dates and marries should also be part of this calculus, it explicitly encourages women to foster friendships and hobbies — namely, 'affective relationalities' — not as ends in and of themselves but instead as part of the self-as-business's capital-enhancing process. When discussing the importance of networking for women just starting out on their career, Trump urges these women to make one new strong bond each time they meet people at a party or conference. 'Your network', she states, 'is one of your greatest resources' (Trump, 2017, p. 67). Although there is some attempt to play down the instrumentalization of other people, the emphasis is nonetheless on the new contact or friend as beneficial for business as well as for enhancing one's own value. As she articulates it: 'The more diverse your contacts are the more likely you'll derive both personal and business benefits down the road' (p. 69). Indeed, both the cultivation of intimacies as well as self-care and leisure activities are transposed into business-like strategies, which also illustrates how neoliberal rationality dissolves traditional forms of social ties and relations, even toward one's self.

What we witness, then, is the economization of domains once closely associated with the non-market interests of the private sphere. Particularly striking is how affect — again, once inextricably linked to the domestic realm — has been transformed into its own form of asset or capital, which now requires smart investment so as to increase the probability of 'dividends' in the future (see also Brown, 2015; Rottenberg, 2017). One's affective attachments are perceived as forms of capital to be cultivated and invested in order to enhance the value of the self's overall portfolio. Savvy self-investment and entrepreneurial strategies of self-care have become paramount. In this way, Trump's how-to-succeed book provides readers with a clear vision of a world in which all spheres of human life have not only become completely saturated by a calculative reason but also reconfigured by neoliberalism's moral imperative to appreciate — or at least maintain — one's own market value as the ultimate aim in life.

Consequently, *Women Who Work* clearly exposes many of the processes by and through which subjects are required to remake themselves into various credit-seeking assets, endlessly working on themselves in order to increase their worth. Trump lays out in some detail the various kinds of temporal, physical, aesthetic and affective investments that women must make in order to ensure that they can manage themselves successfully as capital-enhancing subjects. Taking care of ourselves and professional development are, Trump (2017, p. 104) insists, things that 'we must prioritize so that we … achieve our goals'. These activities are meant to maximize women's value. The text can therefore be read as encouraging and *further* enacting the conversion of aspirational women into generic rather than gendered human capital, and this process is, I suggest, most strikingly and best exemplified in the refiguring of motherhood in managerial terms.

Although Trump does pay tribute to norms of intensive and hands-on motherhood, she simultaneously provides a range of directives about how to better *manage* the caregiving role. She tells us that she writes lists for 'connecting with each of [her] kids', putting real thought into ideas for producing 'memorable moments' she can create with them (Trump, 2017, p. 117). Her approach to care work is calculative and thus reads more like ticking off the right boxes in order to demonstrate 'correct investment' for eventual returns in the form of future memories. She also informs readers that she makes sure to have concrete family goals, which then enable her to pencil in time with her family. Trump (2017, p. 144) then encourages all women to: '[I]dentify your individual goals and priorities, both personal and professional, and structure your time in such a way that you focus … on meeting those obligations.' For Trump, these goals include official date nights with her husband, dates that are scheduled into the general family list well in advance. In *Women Who Work* the realm of reproduction and care is transmogrified into regulated, calculative and carefully planned affective investment. The way in which reproductive and care work is presented here, namely, in more managerial terms — thus undermining in interesting ways discourses of 'natural' female nurturing instincts — gestures to the further saturation of a market metrics into domains that have traditionally upheld the gendered division of labour, attenuating the link between women — or, to be more precise — a certain strata of women — and care work. As a result, the ideal female self who Trump presents potentially undermines traditional notions of sexual difference.

Yet, on the other hand, and crucially — the conversion of 'aspirational' women into generic human capital remains incomplete, and not merely because women are the ones deemed responsible for managing the to-do lists. Rather, Trump's normative trajectory still includes reproduction, while her ideal of female success remains a happy

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work–family balance, which is precisely why *Women Who Work* should be considered a neoliberal feminist manifesto par excellence. Interestingly, Trump (2017, p. 147) ostensibly eschews the notion of work–family balance, claiming that such balance is often impossible on a day-to-day basis, opting, instead, for the term work–life rhythm. However, rhythm turns out to be interchangeable with equilibrium, and the term balance nevertheless reinserts itself into Trump's happiness script when she posits that her overall objective is to 'attain balance over her lifetime', by which she means an equilibrium between being an involved parent and a successful businesswoman, or, in her words, a 'superengaged mom and unabashedly ambitious entrepreneur' (pp. 143, 144). Hence, the work–life rhythm might need to be recalibrated occasionally — or even quite often — in order to ensure happiness, but a happy equilibrium between work and family over time remains the ultimate end game. In this way, reproduction and care work continue to function as a pushback to neoliberalism's conversion of aspirational women into generic subjects.

As a result of its adherence to the how-to-succeed genre, offering step-by-step advice, *Women Who Work* exposes in great and disturbing detail neoliberalism's moral imperative. Through constantly inciting each individual woman to pursue 'savvy self-investment and entrepreneurial strategies of self-care' (Brown, 2016, p. 9), Trump's manifesto helps demonstrate how individual women are being construed as specks of human capital. Indeed, she encourages women to labour ceaselessly on themselves in order to produce, maintain and appreciate themselves *as* human capital albeit without forfeiting reproductive and care work responsibilities. Addressing her reader, Trump (2017) states that she wants to celebrate 'women who work at all aspects of their lives', 'boosting your productivity, maximizing your efficiency, and prioritizing time' (pp. 168, 128). In a sense, then, *Women Who Work* thematizes with disturbing clarity how neoliberal feminist discourses around benchmarks, competition and success are eclipsing demands for equal rights, as well as how notions of the self-as-stock are replacing discussions of autonomy and emancipation, leaving few if any traces of the liberal feminist subject in their wake.

3 | CONCLUSION

In *Undoing the Demos*, Wendy Brown (2015, p. 36) provocatively suggests that neoliberalism's revolution is one that transpires by stealth, termite-like, boring 'in capillary fashion into the trunks and branches of workplaces, public agencies, social and political discourse, and above all, the subject'. Thus, as neoliberal rationality permeates ever more domains of our lives, the conceptual and political boundaries constitutive of liberalism and liberal thought are being undone, while more and more domains are being retooled through market metrics. This dual process of collapse and reconfiguration helps produce the neoliberal feminist subject who stars in Ivanka Trump's *Women Who Work*. Neoliberalism as a political rationality, in other words, not only undoes conceptual boundaries but also — and crucially — brings into being 'new subjects, conduct, relations, and worlds' (Brown, 2015, p. 36).

By way of conclusion, it is important to underscore that *Women Who Work* ultimately fails to address the challenges and difficulties of the vast majority of women who work. Trump's 'how-to-succeed' guide effectively erases from view most of the women (with or without children) who participate in the labour force, many of whom are working in increasingly precarious conditions in the so-called 'gig economy', enduring double shifts, night shifts or taking on two to three jobs just in order to make ends meet.[3] As such, Trump's text resonates and dovetails with Sandberg's (2013) and Slaughter's (2012) well-known neoliberal feminist manifestos, which are unabashedly exclusionary, encompassing as they do only so-called aspirational women in their interpellative address. In this way, neoliberalism feminism also helps to reify white and class privilege as well as heteronormativity.

Given the reality that, most often, women of colour, poor and immigrant women serve as the unacknowledged care workers who enable professional women to strive towards 'balance' in their lives, neoliberal feminism helps to (re)produce and legitimize the exploitation of these 'other' female subjects while simultaneously disarticulating the very vocabulary with which to address the glaring inequalities that these women experience in their daily lives. In one sense, neoliberal feminism enables wages for housework and childrearing by outsourcing these tasks to 'non-aspirational' women. But rather than serving as a path to liberation, wages for housework and care work serve to

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further expand and entrench a market rationality while concurrently creating new and reinforcing old class-based and racialized gender stratification (see Briggs, 2017; Glenn, 2010). Indeed, the outsourcing of reproduction and care work further splits female subjecthood, deepening the bifurcation between the worthy capital-enhancing feminist few and the disavowed female rest. What neoliberal feminism ultimately facilitates, then, is the production of a small class of so-called aspirational subjects who self-invest wisely and augment their capital value, alongside a large class of women who are rendered expendable, exploitable and disposable. This feminism, in sum, forsakes most women, helping to create new and intensified forms of racialized and class-stratified gender exploitation, which increasingly constitutes the invisible yet necessary infrastructure of our new neoliberal order.

Additionally, due to the way in which it serves to bolster neoliberal hegemony, and as part of what Sara Farris and I have called the 'righting of feminism' (Farris & Rottenberg, 2017), neoliberal feminism in no way constitutes a threat to the powers that be. It effectively defangs feminism of its oppositional force by individualizing and responsibilizing women and by helping neoliberal rationality resolve one of its constitutive tensions by maintaining a distinctive lexicon of reproduction and care work. Simultaneously, the notion of a happy work–family balance helps render this variant of feminism palatable and legitimate, enabling neoliberal feminism's widespread embrace and circulation within the Anglo-American mainstream cultural landscape. At present, we inevitably encounter it in multiple sites from bestselling books through mainstream magazine articles and popular television series, such as *The Good Wife*, to well-trafficked mommy blogs.

Precisely because neoliberal feminism incites individual women to 'internalize the revolution' (Sandberg, 2013, p. 11) and focus on themselves and their own aspirations, thus buttressing neoliberalism's hegemony, it can more easily be popularized, sold and capitalized upon in the marketplace. As the 'f-word' has literally inundated mainstream and social media, identifying as feminist has increasingly become a source of pride, serving as cultural capital for celebrities and high-profile women alike (see Banet-Weiser, 2018; Banet-Weiser & Portwood-Stacer, 2017; Farris & Rottenberg, 2017; Gill & Orgad, 2017; Hemmings, 2018; McRobbie, 2013, 2015). The rise of neoliberal feminism has, in other words, helped to render feminism popular in ways few scholars could have predicted just a few years ago. And, yet, this process of popularization may constitute a double-edged sword, since as Susan Buck-Morse (2003) has convincingly argued, power always produces its own vulnerability.

By facilitating feminism's widespread embrace, neoliberal feminism has also — and paradoxically — helped to pave the way for more militant and mass feminist movements, such as #MeToo, the Woman's March and the Global Women's Strike.[4] Clearly some of the infrastructure for the recent oppositional feminist groundswell was already in place. It is crucial to remember that the MeToo campaign initially emerged over a decade ago as part of a grassroots movement spearheaded by the African-American activist Tarana Burke, and that it comes on the heels of other mobilizations, such as SlutWalk, the transnational movement that organized protests across the globe against rape culture and its attendant victim-blaming. But I suggest that in addition to (father) Trump's election and the reappearance of a shameless sexism in the public sphere, which has had its own galvanizing effect, #MeToo was able to gain such widespread traction at this particular moment in history, at least in part, because feminism had already been embraced and rendered desirable by high-powered corporate women like Sheryl Sandberg, Hollywood stars like Emma Watson as well as music celebrities like Beyoncé (Agostinho, 2016) — to name just a few.

Finally, while more visible movements such as #MeToo are currently carrying out important cultural work — (at best) exposing just how thoroughly male entitlement saturates our culture — other feminist movements, such as Feminism for the 99%, which helped organize the Global Women's Strike, have been mobilizing on the ground, widening their reach and significantly expanding the single analytic frame of gender, articulating and protesting a dizzying array of inequalities facing women, minorities and precarious populations more generally. These feminist movements, like their more radical predecessors (Segal, 2017a, 2017b), are demanding dramatic economic, social and cultural transformations, thereby challenging the neoliberal consensus while creating alternative visions that cultivate hope for the future. Given just how bleak the future currently looks for an ever-increasing number of people across the globe, this is exactly the kind of threatening feminism that we need. The urgent question, then, is how we can sustain and broaden this feminist renaissance *as counter-hegemonic*, while rejecting the neoliberal feminist logic informing Ivanka Trump's *Women Who Work*.

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ENDNOTES

[1] Brown also underscores this 'devolution' of responsibility is occurring precisely at a time when social safety nets are being further dismantled.

[2] The notion that we have moved from a postfeminist moment to a feminist one is a contested one. See, for example, Gill (2016) and Lewis and Simpson (2017) who suggest that the recent upsurge in feminist discourse should be seen as part and parcel of a postfeminist sensibility and its particular gender regime.

[3] See the National Women's Law Center website: https://nwlc.org/issue/poverty-economic-security

[4] Of course, father Trump's election and policies are also part of this larger picture. One of the great ironies here is that even as Ivanka Trump has written a neoliberal feminist manifesto par excellence, her father's unabashedly sexist administration has galvanized the feminist resistance.

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